

A first look at Chern–Simons theory

Flat connections, anyons, and a boundary

11 September 2026

Chern–Simons theory is a useful example of a field theory whose bulk information is global. This short note focuses on a compact Abelian gauge field in $2 + 1$ dimensions. The non-Abelian generalization carries a much richer set of line operators; it is not needed for the basic mechanism below.

1 An action without a metric

Set $\hbar = 1$, let M be oriented spacetime, and write $a = a_\mu dx^\mu$ for a compact $U(1)$ connection. With $\epsilon^{012} = +1$, choose the sign convention

$$S[a] = -\frac{k}{4\pi} \int_M a \wedge da = -\frac{k}{4\pi} \int d^3x \epsilon^{\mu\nu\rho} a_\mu \partial_\nu a_\rho. \quad (1)$$

Here k is a nonzero integer; reversing the orientation reverses the chirality. No metric is required to write this action. This is different from a Maxwell term, which contracts field strengths with a metric and introduces propagating bulk dynamics.

Ignoring boundary terms for the moment, variation gives

$$\delta S = -\frac{k}{2\pi} \int_M \delta a \wedge da, \quad da = 0. \quad (2)$$

A flat connection is locally pure gauge, $a = d\lambda$, so pure Chern–Simons theory has no local bulk wave modes. It need not be globally trivial: $\oint a$ can be nonzero around a noncontractible cycle. The action is classical and metric independent; defining the quantum theory also entails global data, including the familiar framing dependence.

The compactness assumption matters. Requiring a well-defined exponentiated action under large gauge transformations quantizes k . With the usual $U(1)$ normalization, odd k defines a spin theory and requires a spin structure; a purely bosonic definition on general oriented manifolds requires even k . A local integration by parts alone does not establish these global statements [1, 2].

2 Flux attachment in one equation

Couple a conserved probe current through $\int d^3x a_\mu j^\mu$. A line carrying integer charge l has the Wilson factor $\exp(il \oint a)$. Varying a_0 gives the Gauss constraint

$$-\frac{k}{2\pi} b + j^0 = 0, \quad b = \partial_x a_y - \partial_y a_x, \quad \int b d^2x = \frac{2\pi l}{k}. \quad (3)$$

Thus a probe charge carries gauge flux. This is emergent gauge flux, not automatically the physical magnetic field in a material.

3 Braiding and the information on a torus

Move a charge l' once counterclockwise around charge l , using the orientation of Eq. (3). Its Aharonov–Bohm phase is

$$\theta_{\text{mutual}} = l' \oint a = \frac{2\pi ll'}{k} \pmod{2\pi}. \quad (4)$$

For the elementary Abelian line of charge l , the exchange phase in this convention is $\theta_l = \pi l^2/k$ modulo 2π . A full braid of two identical particles is two exchanges. These phases depend on winding, not on the detailed shape or speed of the path within the topological approximation.

Example. For $k = 2$ and $l = 1$, the exchange phase is $\pi/2$: the excitation is a semion. Two such excitations fuse to a local bosonic sector. At odd k , attaching the local fermion can change an exchange phase by π , which is why the spin-theory qualification above is useful.

On a spatial torus, flatness still leaves two cycle holonomies, $\alpha = \oint_x a$ and $\beta = \oint_y a$, each periodic by 2π . Substitution into Eq. (1) gives, up to a total time derivative,

$$L = \frac{k}{2\pi} \alpha \dot{\beta}. \quad (5)$$

The compact holonomy phase space has symplectic area $2\pi|k|$. Quantization therefore gives $|k|$ states; on a closed genus- g surface the dimension is $|k|^g$. In a microscopic gapped realization, finite-size effects can split this topological degeneracy by exponentially small amounts.

4 Why a boundary changes the story

For $a \mapsto a + d\lambda$, the action changes by

$$\delta_\lambda S = -\frac{k}{4\pi} \int_{\partial M} \lambda da. \quad (6)$$

It vanishes on a closed manifold but need not vanish at a boundary. One must specify boundary conditions, restrict the allowed gauge transformations, or include boundary degrees of freedom with a compensating variation. In a quantum Hall application, a chiral edge field supplies this cancellation.

The bulk coefficient fixes topological data such as braiding. It does not fix an edge velocity, which depends on microscopic energetics. This separation explains how a topological bulk theory can coexist with a dynamical, gapless boundary.

Useful check. Whenever a Chern–Simons coefficient appears, ask which field is dynamical, whether the gauge group is compact, which orientation is used, and whether a boundary is present. Those choices prevent many apparent sign and quantization paradoxes.

References

- [1] G. V. Dunne, *Aspects of Chern–Simons Theory*, Les Houches lectures (1998). [arXiv:hep-th/9902115](#).
- [2] D. Tong, *Lectures on the Quantum Hall Effect* (2016), especially the effective field theory and edge-mode chapters. [arXiv:1606.06687](#).